

BASKET HEAD

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

GENERAL PITCH:

In Basket Head, the player takes control of a new beekeeper in a medieval coastal village, donning that ever-friendly basket mask to protect them from bees. By day, the player will tend to their bees, collecting honey from their hives which they will then sell. However, all is not what it seems. Beneath the ancient apiary lies many secrets that are better off left forgotten. Cursed knowledge of the Bees of old corrupts the land....



INSPIRATION:



Dredge

Dredge presents players with an inherently relaxing premise and turns that on its head with eldritch themes and tones. Thematically, we're doing something similar here, providing players with what appears to be a relaxing beekeeping game that quickly yields to a spooky experience the more the player plays.



Don't Starve

Gameplay-wise, Basket Head will play a lot like *Don't Starve*. The player will experience the world via isometric sprites with a distinct art style. The player character will be walking around, building structures, and picking up items. Although in this prototype, there won't be much of a crafting system if at all. We also don't plan on adding any survival mechanics to the game.

THE PLAYER EXPERIENCE

The Basket Head prototype will consist of a single predetermined apiary map where the player will be able to place flowers and hives freely as they spread eldritch corruption.



Gameplay Loop

Basket Head is a casual Beekeeping sim. The general gameplay revolves around planting flowers, tending to your hives, raising money by selling honey, and unleashing eldritch terror upon the world, all without raising too much suspicion along the way. The goal of Basket Head is to spread the corruption of the Eldritch god **Bzzzulhu** using your bees and corrupted flowers.

Going forward, we would like to add in more rogue-lite elements, but we cut them for this Game Jam.



Beekeeping Mechanics

Tending to the bees in this game is basically making sure there are normal and corrupted flowers available for your hives and gathering honey to sell. If the hives are hungry, they won't produce much honey.

Hives

Hives contain **seven bees** that go out into the apiary each day to gather pollen, both corrupted and regular. When there is enough pollen of either type, honey is produced corresponding to the type of pollen. **Honey is worth 10 gold and corrupted honey is worth 20.**



Beehives will become progressively more 'eldritch' as corrupted pollen is collected from corrupted flowers by its bees.



Bee Behavior

Bees will behave simply. At night, they will reside in the hive, and during the day they will simply go to a random number of flowers, gather pollen, and return to the hive where they will deposit the pollen.

When a bee becomes corrupted, **it will spread corruption onto flowers they visit** and, in turn, corrupt the flowers. It is in the player's best interest to place flowers near their beehives to allow bees to corrupt more flowers.

The Bzzzulhu Statue

The initial source of corruption for the apiary will be this lovely statue of **Bzzzulhu**. Some corrupted flowers will spawn in with it.

Day Night Cycle

The game will have a **day-night cycle** to show the passage of time. In the day, bees will venture out normally and gather pollen for their hive. At night, the shady **merchant** will appear, selling seeds, fresh corpses, and empty hives they can place throughout their apiary.

Later in development, we would like to add visitors that can show up at the apiary.



Flowers

To feed the bees, the player must make flowers abundant in their apiary. The type of flower will be determined by what kind of soil it is placed in. Clean soil will provide a normal flower that will produce regular honey.



Corrupted soil or a **fresh grave** will produce **corrupted flowers**, which will allow corrupted honey to be produced.



There is a chance that **corrupted flowers will corrupt any bees that gather from it**. Bees leaving a flower will carry back pollen to the hive. Once a certain threshold of pollen is hit, the hive's honey level will increase. When a flower is planted it will take a day or so to sprout.

Corruption Mechanics

In order to adhere to the Game Jam theme, **the player must spread eldritch corruption throughout the apiary**. Bees, hives, and flowers each have 3 stages of corruption: regular, changing, and corrupted. Each of these stages will cause the object to update its sprite, along with spreading corruption to whatever it interacts with.



An example of a flower progressing through stages of corruption. This corruption will then spread to nearby plants and eventually take over the entire apiary!

Music

For the music we decided to go with an atmospheric track during gameplay. This would be mostly calming in feel, but have some ominous tones to suggest there is something afoot within the apiary. The main menu theme also employs a similar thematic feel, only with a more upbeat chorus.

The shopkeeper will also have his own theme in the game to distinguish the store environment from the apiary experience.

THE ART STYLE

Since our game takes place in the Middle Ages, we decided to reference art from that period, especially **illuminated manuscripts** which were fairly common at that time. Various intertwining plants, decorative floral elements, and uncanny people and settings felt like the perfect style for an eldritch game.

Also, in keeping with the Game Jam's theme of corruption, the color of corrupted plants and animals will bleed past their outlines—perhaps the events of Basket Head are occurring on the page of a manuscript too, whose illustrator is losing their mind to corruption!



Here are some examples of sprites in our game inspired from illustrations from historical manuscripts:



An illustration of bees returning to a skep hive inspired the look of the game's beehive. Even the foliage was taken to populate the game's environment!



This illustration depicts animals found on Noah's ark. The square composition felt appropriate for item inventory and other UI elements within the game.



Although not from a medieval manuscript, this illustration shows a beekeeper dress which was commonly used throughout the Middle Ages.

Flowers are often depicted in these early texts, such as this cornflower.